

How are we to live?

Evidence-based pointers on living well

Trust, but verify

Every claim here carries its **study design**, its **effect size**, and its **honest weakness** — and links to the paper.

- Don't be a cynic who believes nothing, or a pushover who believes everything.
- Believe things **in proportion to the evidence** — then go and check.

This whole thing assumes you care what happens next. If you don't, there's nothing here for you.

Two different clocks

The usual advice is almost all about the **70-year clock**.
Your next decade — the **10-year clock** — is a different list.

10-year clock (you, now)	70-year clock (lifetime)
Don't start nicotine	Smoking
Alcohol & acute injury	Physical inactivity
Road (belt, helmet)	Diet / food environment
Gambling on a phone	Alcohol · Gambling
Sleep & mood	Sun · Sleep

The two lists barely overlap. Knowing **which clock** a message is on is half the point.

Smoking kills — stopping helps

- Smokers die on average **~10 years** younger; two-thirds are killed by it (British Doctors Study; Banks 2015).
- **But:** stopping before 40 avoids **>90%** of the excess risk; before 30, **>97%** (Pirie 2013).
- And quitting is **achievable** — comprehensive support plus medicines (varenicline **RR 2.32**, NRT **RR 1.55**).

Almost everyone who smokes for life starts young: **not starting** removes the whole problem.

Alcohol: no safe dose

- Risk rises from the **first drink** — the old "protective" J-curve was confounding (Millwood, genetic study 2019).
- **But** it's a claim about the *shape* of the curve, not the *size*: one drink's risk is small.
- For a teenager the danger is **tonight** — injury, not cirrhosis in thirty years.

Gambling: designed so you lose

No statistics needed — the house edge is a **published design parameter**.

- Roulette: **2.7%** (single-zero), **5.26%** (double). Online slots keep **4-8%** of everything staked.
- You are not unlucky — you are on the wrong side of a number the company **chose and published**.
- Harm tracks the **product** (fast, continuous), not the personality.

Eat food. Mostly plants. Not too much.

- Excess body fat **causally** raises type-2 diabetes, heart disease, **13 cancers** and mortality (genetic studies; IARC).
- The body **defends** fat once gained, and it tracks from childhood — **prevention beats reversal**.
- You eat more when food is processed and portions are big.
Change the defaults, not your willpower.

The stakes are well-evidenced; the "right diet" is the weak part — so change the environment.

Move more, sit less

- The biggest gain is simply **leaving the least-active group** — the curve is front-loaded (Ekelund 2019).
- There is **no magic number** to hit.
- It lifts your **mood now**: activity causally lowers depression (Choi 2019). Try **parkrun** — free, weekly, walk or run.

Sleep like it matters

- Best-evidenced as a **short-term** lever on mood and attention — the two weeks, not the fifty years.
- Teenage body clocks **run late** — biology, not laziness.
- Basics help: regular hours, dark room, **dim evening screens**, no late caffeine. (*Real insomnia → CBT-I, not a checklist.*)

Slip, slop, slap

- The **best study design** on the whole list — an actual randomised trial (Nambour).
- Daily sunscreen roughly **halved melanomas**, ten years after the trial ended.
- Melanoma is already common in **15-34s**; sunbeds are a Group 1 carcinogen. Both clocks agree.

Change the rules, not just yourself

The biggest gains came from the **shared environment**, not from trying harder.

- Smoke-free laws: heart-attack admissions ↓ **17%** (Scotland).
- Minimum unit pricing: alcohol deaths ↓ **13.4%**. Sugar levy: drinks reformulated.
- As you come of age, **engaging and voting** for health-promoting policy is itself a high-leverage act.

You cannot out-willpower a design.

But you can see it.

Smoking kills — stopping helps. Alcohol: no safe dose. Gambling: designed so you lose.

Eat food, mostly plants, not too much. Move more, sit less. Sleep like it matters. Slip, slop, slap.

Trust, but verify — the full evidence, with its weaknesses and links, is on the site.